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The Iliad

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BOOK I

The Anger of Achilles

Sing, goddess, of the wrath of Peleus' son Achilles, the ruinous wrath that brought unnumbered grief upon the Achaeans, and sent many brave souls before their time into the house of Hades, making their bodies prey for dogs and every bird—while Zeus's will was brought toward fulfillment—from that first hour when Atreus' son, the king of men, and godlike Achilles stood at odds. Who, then, among the gods joined them in strife? The son of Leto and of Zeus. For he, angered against the king, sent through the host a deadly plague; and the people perished, because Agamemnon had dishonored Chryses, the priest, who came before the swift ships, to ransom his dear daughter, bearing gifts beyond all measure, and in his hands the wreath and golden staff of far-darting Apollo; he prayed to all the Achaeans, but most of all to Atreus' sons, the marshals of the people. The priest came then to the shore, and prayed to Apollo, the lord who bears the silver bow, and called upon him: "Hear me, you of the fair hair, you who keep Chryse and holy Cilla, and who rule Tenedos in power; if ever I have built you a pleasing temple, or burned for you the rich thigh-pieces of bulls and goats, grant this desire: let the Danaans pay for my tears beneath your arrows." So he prayed, and Phoebus Apollo heard him. Down from Olympus he came, his heart full of anger, carrying his bow and covered quiver. The arrows rang upon his shoulder as the god moved; and he sat apart from the ships, then loosed a shaft. First the mules and swift hounds he struck; afterward he turned his bitter arrows against the men. Through all the camp the pyres burned without rest. For nine days the shafts of the god went forth. On the tenth, Achilles called the people to assembly. Hera of the white arms had put the thought within him, grieving for the Danaans as she watched them perish. When they had gathered, Achilles rose among them:

"Son of Atreus, soon we shall be driven back again, wandering among the waves, if any man remains alive.

Come, let us ask a seer, or priest, or interpreter of dreams—for dreams are also from Zeus—to tell us

why Phoebus is so bitter, whether he blames our vows

or hecatombs, and whether he might meet us again and ward the ruin off by the savor of lambs and goats made perfect in sacrifice."

He sat, and Calchas rose among them, Thestor's son,

the best of augurs, who knew what is, what was, and what will be,

and who had led the Achaean ships to Ilium by that prophetic art Apollo gave to him.

With thoughtful speech he answered them and said:

"Achilles, dear to Zeus, you ask me to declare the wrath of Apollo, lord of the far-shooting bow. I will speak it;

but swear to stand beside me, and be ready in word and hand. For I think that man

will soon be angered against me, the one who rules the Argives, and whose word the army must obey.

No light thing is a king's resentment; stronger is a king when angered against a lesser man. If he hides

his anger for a day, it grows and waits for payment."

Achilles answered him: "Speak freely. No one here, while I draw breath and look upon the light of day, shall lift a hand against you—not Agamemnon, though he names himself the greatest of the Greeks."

Then the blameless seer took courage and spoke:

"No vow, no hecatomb, no offering is lacking.

The god's wrath is for Chryses and his daughter, whom Agamemnon will not release. Send her home,

without a price or ransom; sacrifice at Chryse.

Then the god may turn from us and end the plague."

Agamemnon, anger still black around his heart, rose and spoke to Calchas first:

"Prophet of evil, never have you spoken good to me. You love to prophesy what brings the army sorrow; you have never spoken a good word or brought it to pass.

And now among the Danaans you declare that the far-shooter

deals them pain because I would not accept the shining ransom
 for Chryseis, because I desired to keep her in my house.
 I prefer her even to Clytemnestra, my wedded wife; she is not less than Clytemnestra in form, in stature,
 in mind, or in the work of her hands. Still, I will give her back,
 if that is better. I would rather keep my people safe than see them die.
 But make ready another prize for me at once, so that I alone
 among the Argives do not go without my honor—you all see
 that my prize is being carried elsewhere.”
 Achilles, swift of foot, looked at him darkly and answered:
 “Son of Atreus, most glorious and most greedy of all men,
 how shall the great-hearted Achaeans give you a prize?
 We know of no common stores lying in abundance here:
 the spoils from the cities we took have been divided,
 and it would not be fitting to gather the people together
 and make them give those portions back. Send this girl
 to the god now; and when we take Troy’s well-built city,
 we shall pay you three and four times over, if Zeus grants it.”
 Agamemnon, king of men, replied:
 “Do not, godlike Achilles, though you are good, hide your thought
 and try to deceive me; you will not slip past me or persuade me.
 Do you want to keep your own prize while I sit here without one,
 and command me to give this girl away? If the great-hearted Achaeans
 give me a prize, making it fit my desire, so be it. But if they do not,
 I myself will take one—yours, Ajax’s, or Odysseus’s—and carry it away.
 The man I visit will be angry; we shall settle that another time.
 For now, haul the black ship down to the shining sea,
 gather rowers in proper number, put the hecatomb aboard,
 and send fair-cheeked Chryseis. Let one of the counselors lead:

Ajax, Idomeneus, godlike Odysseus—or you, son of Peleus,
 most terrible of men—so that you may appease the far-shooter
 by performing the holy rites.”
 Achilles, looking darkly at him, answered:
 “Ah, clothed in shamelessness and bent on gain—who among the Achaeans
 will follow you freely, whether to march or fight in battle?
 I did not come here to fight the spear-famed Trojans for my own sake:
 they have never wronged me. They never drove off my cattle or my horses;
 they never in Phthia, rich in soil and men, destroyed my harvest—
 there are shadowed mountains and the sounding sea between us.
 No: we followed you, great shameless one, to win honor for Menelaus
 and for you, dog-face, from the Trojans—though you neither notice nor care.
 And now you threaten to take from me the prize for which I labored,
 which the sons of the Achaeans gave me. I never receive a prize equal to yours
 when the Achaeans sack a well-inhabited Trojan city;
 my hands bear the greater burden of the furious war.
 But when the division comes, your prize is far larger,
 while I carry a small but cherished portion to my ships,
 after I have grown weary fighting. Now I will go to Phthia:
 it is far better to sail home in my curved ships than to remain here dishonored and heap up
 wealth and treasure for you.”
 “Go, then, if your heart urges you; I do not beg you to stay for my sake.
 There are others here who will honor me, and Zeus above all,
 the counselor. You are the most hateful of the kings he nourishes.
 Strife, wars, and battles are always dear to you. If you are mighty, some god has given you that gift.
 Go home with your ships and companions, rule your Myrmidons;
 I care nothing for your wrath, nor do I count it as a threat.
 But this I tell you: as Phoebus Apollo takes Chryseis from me,

I will send her away in my ship with my
 companions;
 then I myself will go to your hut and take
 fair-cheeked Briseis,
 your prize, so that you may know how much
 stronger I am than you,
 and that every other man may fear to call himself
 my equal."
 Then grief and anger gathered in Achilles' chest.
 He weighed two thoughts: to draw his sword from
 his thigh
 and scatter the assembly, or to master his heart and
 endure.
 As he drew the great blade, Athena came down
 from heaven,
 sent by the white-armed goddess Hera, who loved
 both men.
 She stood behind him, visible to him alone, and
 caught his hair.
 Achilles turned and said: "Why have you come,
 child of Zeus?
 To watch the insolence of Agamemnon? I tell you
 this:
 his life, I think, will soon pay for what he has done."
 The goddess of flashing eyes answered him:
 "I came to restrain you. Put away the sword.
 Speak against him as fiercely as you will, but do not
 strike.
 One day, for this dishonor, gifts three times over
 will be set before you. Hold your hand and obey."
 Achilles answered: "A man must obey you, goddess,
 though anger burns. It is better so. Whoever obeys
 the gods,
 the gods hear him in return." He drove the blade
 back
 into its sheath, and Athena rose again to Olympus.
 Then he faced the son of Atreus and spoke once
 more:
 "You who wear a dog's eyes and carry a deer's heart,
 never do you arm with the people for battle,
 never go with the best into an ambush or the line.
 That would be death to you. It is easier to walk the
 camp
 and strip a man of his prize. You rule men who
 obey you,
 because you are a king who feeds upon his own
 people.
 Otherwise, son of Atreus, this would be your last
 outrage.
 But I swear a great oath: by this staff, which will
 never again
 put forth leaf or branch, since bronze cut it from
 the mountain

and stripped its bark, and now judges carry it in
 their hands,
 judges who keep the laws that come from Zeus—
 so surely shall a day come when all the Achaeans
 will long for Achilles. Then, though you suffer, you
 cannot help them,
 when Hector, breaker of ranks, kills men beside
 their ships.
 You will tear your heart for the champion you
 dishonored."
 He flung the gold-studded staff upon the ground
 and sat.
 Across from him Agamemnon still raged. But
 Nestor rose,
 the clear-speaking elder from Pylos, whose tongue
 flowed sweeter
 than honey. Two generations of mortal men had
 passed before him,
 and now he ruled among the third. He addressed
 them:
 "What sorrow has come upon the Achaean land!
 The Trojans would rejoice, and Priam's sons, and
 all the rest,
 if they could hear you. End this quarrel. You are
 both younger
 than I, and I have stood beside men greater than
 you.
 Yet they listened when I spoke, and followed my
 counsel.
 Listen now. You, Agamemnon, do not take the girl;
 let her remain. And you, Achilles, do not contend
 with the king, since no other scepter-bearing man
 has honor equal to his. If you are the stronger, still
 he is greater
 in rank, and more men obey him."
 Achilles cut him off: "No coward would endure
 your words.
 Let others take your commands; do not command
 me:
 I do not think I shall obey you any longer. And
 mark this well:
 I will not fight you with my hands for the girl's
 sake,
 nor you, nor any other man, since you have taken
 her from me.
 But of all the other things I have beside my swift
 black ship,
 you shall carry off none against my will. Come—try
 it,
 so that these men may see: your black blood will
 run around my spear."
 They broke the assembly. Achilles went to his ships
 with Patroclus and his companions. Agamemnon
 hauled a swift ship

down to the sea, chose twenty rowers, and put
 aboard
 the hecatomb for the god. He led fair-cheeked
 Chryseis aboard,
 and set wise Odysseus as captain. They climbed in
 and sailed
 the wet roads of the sea; meanwhile Agamemnon
 ordered the army
 to cleanse itself. They washed and cast the filth into
 the sea,
 then sacrificed perfect hecatombs of bulls and goats
 to Apollo
 beside the shore of the barren sea; the smoke curled
 upward to heaven.
 But the king did not cease from the quarrel he had
 first threatened.
 He called Talthylus and Eurybates, his heralds
 and eager servants:
 "Go to the hut of Achilles, son of Peleus; take
 fair-cheeked Briseis
 by the hand and lead her here. If he will not give
 her, I myself
 will come with more men and take her—and that
 will be worse for him."
 They went unwillingly along the barren shore and
 came to the huts
 and ships of the Myrmidons. They found Achilles
 sitting beside
 his hut and black ship. He was not glad to see them.
 They stood,
 afraid and ashamed before the king, and said
 nothing.
 Achilles knew why they had come and spoke first:
 "Hail, heralds, messengers of Zeus and of men.
 Come nearer.
 You are not to blame; Agamemnon is to blame,
 who sent you
 for the girl. Patroclus, beloved companion, bring
 her out
 and give her to them. Let these two be witnesses
 before the blessed gods,
 before mortal men, and before the harsh king
 himself, if ever again
 there is need of me to ward disgraceful death from
 the others.
 For he sacrifices with a mind bent on destruction;
 he does not know
 how to think at once of what is before him and
 what is behind,
 so that the Achaeans beside the ships might fight in
 safety."
 Patroclus obeyed his beloved companion. He led
 fair-cheeked Briseis
 from the hut and gave her to the heralds, who
 returned to the Achaean ships.

The woman went unwillingly. Achilles sat apart
 from his companions,
 weeping, on the shore of the gray sea, and looked
 out across the boundless water.
 He stretched both hands toward his dear mother
 and prayed:
 "Mother, since you bore me though I was doomed
 to a short life,
 at least Olympian Zeus, the high-thundering one,
 should have granted me honor;
 but now he has honored me not even a little.
 Agamemnon,
 son of Atreus, wide-ruling, has dishonored me: he
 has taken my prize,
 and keeps it for himself."
 His mother heard him from the depths of the sea,
 seated beside her old father.
 Swiftly she rose from the gray sea like a mist, sat
 before her weeping son,
 caressed him with her hand, and called him by
 name:
 "Child, why do you weep? What grief has come into
 your heart?
 Speak out; do not hide it within you. Let us both
 know."
 With a heavy groan Achilles answered:
 "You know it. Why should I tell it all to you, who
 know it already?
 We went to sacred Thebes, the city of Eetion; we
 sacked it
 and brought everything here. The sons of the
 Achaeans divided it fairly
 among themselves, but they chose fair-cheeked
 Chryseis for Agamemnon.
 Then Chryses, priest of far-darting Apollo, came to
 the swift ships
 of the bronze-clad Achaeans to ransom his
 daughter, bringing
 immeasurable gifts and holding in his hands the
 wreath and golden staff
 of the far-shooting god. He begged all the
 Achaeans,
 and above all the two sons of Atreus, commanders
 of the people.
 All the other Achaeans approved: they urged
 reverence for the priest
 and acceptance of the shining ransom. But
 Agamemnon's heart did not consent;
 he sent the old man away harshly and laid a strong
 command upon him.
 The old man went back in anger, and Apollo heard
 his prayer,
 for he loved him dearly. He shot a deadly arrow
 among the Argives,

and the people died one after another as the god's
 shafts moved everywhere
 through the wide camp of the Achaeans. Then the
 prophet who knew the god's will
 spoke among us. I was the first to order that the
 god be appeased.
 But anger seized the son of Atreus; he rose at once
 and threatened me—
 and the threat is now fulfilled. The Achaeans are
 sending Chryseis
 to Chryse in the swift ship, with gifts for the lord;
 and heralds have just taken from my hut Briseis,
 the girl the sons of the Achaeans gave me. Now, if
 you can,
 protect your son: go to Olympus and supplicate
 Zeus. If ever
 you helped his heart by word or deed—for many
 times in my father's house
 I heard you boast that you alone among the
 immortals saved the dark-clouded
 son of Cronus from disgrace, when Hera, Poseidon,
 and Athena
 wanted to bind him. You came and loosed him,
 goddess,
 quickly calling to high Olympus the
 Hundred-Handed One,
 whom the gods call Briareus and men Aegaeon,
 stronger even than his father;
 he sat beside the son of Cronus in glory, and the
 blessed gods feared him
 and did not bind Zeus. Remind him of this, sit
 beside him, and clasp his knees,
 if he will somehow help the Trojans, drive the
 Achaeans back to their ships
 and the sea, and let them be cut down, so that all
 may profit by their king;
 so that Agamemnon may learn what madness he
 committed when he dishonored
 the best of the Achaeans.”
 Thetis answered him, weeping:
 “Ah, my child, why did I raise you, bearing such
 bitter grief?
 Would that you could sit beside the ships without
 tears and without pain,
 since your portion of life is short and not long at
 all.
 But now you are short-lived and more miserable
 than all men;
 for an evil destiny I bore you in my halls. I will go
 myself
 to Olympus, to Zeus who delights in thunder, and
 tell him these things,
 to see if he will listen. But for now sit beside your
 swift ships,

hold your wrath against the Achaeans, and
 withdraw altogether from war.
 For Zeus went yesterday to Ocean and the
 blameless Ethiopians to feast,
 and all the gods went with him. On the twelfth day
 he will return to Olympus;
 then I will go to his bronze-floored house, clasp his
 knees,
 and I think I shall persuade him.”
 Meanwhile Odysseus reached sacred Chryse,
 bringing the holy hecatomb. When they entered
 the deep harbor,
 they furled the sails, laid them in the black ship,
 lowered the mast into its rest, and rowed swiftly to
 anchorage.
 They cast out the anchors and made fast the
 stern-lines;
 then they stepped ashore through the breakers,
 and brought out the hecatomb for the far-shooting
 god.
 Chryseis too came down from the seafaring ship.
 Wise Odysseus led her to the altar, placed her in
 her dear father's hands,
 and spoke: “Chryses, Agamemnon, king of men,
 sent me
 to bring your child and sacrifice this holy hecatomb
 to Phoebus
 for the Danaans, so that we may appease the lord
 who has brought such grievous sorrows upon the
 Argives.”
 He placed her in her father's hands, and the old
 man received his child
 with joy. The Achaeans then set the well-built
 hecatomb
 around the altar of the far-shooter, washed their
 hands,
 and lifted the barley for the rite. Chryses prayed
 aloud,
 his hands raised to heaven:
 “Hear me, god of the silver bow, who guard Chryse,
 holy Cilla, and rule Tenedos in strength.
 You heard me before when I prayed; you honored
 me
 and struck the Achaean people with a great blow.
 Grant me this wish once more: defend the Danaans
 now
 from their shameful plague.”
 So he prayed, and Phoebus Apollo heard him.
 When they had prayed and scattered the barley,
 they drew back the heads,
 cut the throats, flayed the victims, and cut out the
 thighs.
 They wrapped them in fat, laid raw flesh upon
 them,

and the old man burned them on split wood,
 pouring bright wine over them;
 young men stood beside him with five-pronged
 forks in their hands.
 When the thighs had burned and they had tasted
 the inward parts,
 they cut the rest into pieces, pierced it on spits,
 roasted it carefully, and drew all the meat away.
 When the work was finished and the feast
 prepared,
 they ate, and no man's heart lacked an equal
 portion.
 When they had satisfied hunger and thirst, the
 young men filled the mixing bowls,
 and poured the wine into every cup, beginning on
 the right.
 All day the young Achaeans appeased the god with
 song,
 singing the beautiful paean and praising the
 far-shooter;
 and he rejoiced to hear them.
 When the sun had set and darkness came, they
 slept beside the ship.
 When rose the early-born, rosy-fingered Dawn,
 they sailed back toward the wide Achaean camp.
 The far-shooter sent them a fair wind. They raised
 the mast,
 spread the white sails, and the wind filled the
 middle canvas.
 The purple wave roared around the speeding ship's
 stern,
 and she ran across the sea, cutting her road through
 the water.
 When they reached the broad camp of the
 Achaeans,
 they hauled the black ship high upon the mainland
 sand,
 set long props beneath it, and scattered to their
 huts and ships.
 But godlike Achilles, swift of foot, remained beside
 his swift ships,
 holding his wrath. He never went to the assembly
 that brings men glory,
 never went out to battle; his dear heart wasted
 where he sat,
 longing for the battle-cry and the war.
 When the twelfth dawn had appeared, all the
 everlasting gods
 went together to Olympus, with Zeus leading them.
 Thetis did not forget her son's command. She rose
 from the sea
 and climbed like mist through the great heavens to
 Olympus.

She found the wide-seeing son of Cronus sitting
 apart from the others
 on the highest peak of many-ridged Olympus. She
 sat before him,
 clasped his knees with her left hand, touched his
 chin with her right,
 and supplicated Zeus, the son of Cronus:
 "Father Zeus, if ever among the immortals I helped
 you
 by word or deed, fulfill this wish for me.
 Honor my son, who is doomed to die before all
 others.
 Agamemnon, king of men, has dishonored him;
 he took his prize and keeps it for himself.
 But honor him, Olympian Zeus, counselor of the
 gods;
 give the Trojans strength until the Achaeans honor
 my son
 and increase his standing."
 She spoke. Zeus, gatherer of clouds, did not answer.
 He sat long in silence. Thetis held fast to his knees
 and asked him once more:
 "Give me an unfailing promise and incline your
 head,
 or refuse me—there is no fear in you—so I may
 know
 how utterly I am dishonored among the gods."
 Zeus groaned heavily and answered:
 "Ah, what a difficult task you set me: Hera will
 quarrel with me
 when she taunts me with reproachful words.
 Even without this, she is always scolding me before
 the immortals,
 and says that I aid the Trojans in battle.
 Go back now, before Hera notices. I will remember
 this
 and bring it to fulfillment. To make you trust me,
 I will nod with my head; there is no greater sign
 among the immortals.
 What I confirm with a nod cannot be revoked,
 denied,
 or left unfulfilled."
 The son of Cronus bent his dark brows and
 nodded.
 His immortal hair streamed forward from his head,
 and he shook great Olympus beneath him.
 So they took counsel and parted. Thetis plunged
 into the deep sea
 from bright Olympus, while Zeus went to his own
 house.
 All the gods rose from their seats together when
 their father approached;
 none dared remain seated to meet him.

Hera of the white arms had not failed to see him.
 She knew
 that the silver-footed Thetis, daughter of the old
 man of the sea,
 had shared his counsels. At once she spoke with
 taunting words:
 "Who was it now, crafty one, who shared your
 secret counsel?
 You always love to think in secret, apart from me,
 and never willingly tell me what you have decided."
 The father of gods and men answered her:
 "Hera, do not hope to know all my thoughts.
 They will be difficult for you, though you are my
 wife.
 No one else, god or man, will learn first the thought
 that I wish to keep apart from everyone."
 Ox-eyed, revered Hera answered:
 "Most terrible son of Cronus, what have you said?
 I neither ask you nor question you; sit quietly and
 think
 whatever you wish. But I fear terribly that
 silver-footed Thetis,
 daughter of the old man of the sea, came to you at
 dawn,
 sat beside you, and clasped your knees.
 I think you promised her truly to honor Achilles
 and destroy many Achaeans beside their ships."
 Zeus, gatherer of clouds, answered:
 "Strange one, you are always thinking and never
 escape my notice.
 Yet you will accomplish nothing; you will only
 become farther from my heart.
 And that will be worse for you. Sit down in silence
 and obey my word,
 lest all the gods on Olympus fail to help you when I
 stretch
 my invincible hands against you."
 Hera fell silent, afraid, and sat with her heart
 subdued.
 The heavenly gods within Zeus's house were
 troubled.
 Then Hephaestus, famous for his craft, rose to
 speak,
 bringing comfort to his dear, white-armed mother:
 "This will be a disastrous and unbearable thing
 if you two quarrel so over mortal men,
 and bring disorder among the gods. There will be
 no joy
 in the good feast, because the worse thing has
 prevailed.
 I urge my mother—and she knows this herself—to
 bring comfort
 to our dear father Zeus, so that he will not scold
 her again

and disturb our feast."
 He leapt up and placed a beautiful double cup
 in his mother's hands, and spoke again:
 "Endure, my mother, and bear it, though you love
 me dearly,
 lest I see you struck before my eyes and be unable
 to help you.
 It is hard to stand against the Olympian. Once
 before,
 when I came eager to defend you, he seized me by
 the foot
 and hurled me from the threshold of heaven.
 All day I fell, and at sunset I landed in Lemnos,
 with little life remaining. There the Sintian men
 cared for me at once."
 He spoke, and the white-armed goddess Hera
 smiled,
 smiling, she accepted the cup from her son's hand.
 He poured sweet nectar for all the other gods in
 turn,
 drawing it from the mixing bowl. Unquenchable
 laughter rose
 among the blessed gods when they saw Hephaestus
 bustling through the hall.
 So they feasted all day until the sun went down,
 and no heart lacked its equal portion—not Apollo's
 beautiful lyre,
 nor the Muses' lovely answering song.
 When the sun's bright light had set, each god went
 to his own house,
 where famous, lame-footed Hephaestus had built a
 dwelling
 with his knowing mind. Zeus, Olympian lord of the
 thunderbolt,
 went to the bed where he had slept before
 whenever sweet sleep came upon him.
 He climbed into it and slept; beside him lay Hera
 of the golden throne.